12 For instance, Kazakhstan has been squeezed by the recent economic and strategic closeness of Russia and China (post-Ukraine events) and wished for a more diversified space to protect its energy interests. States like Kazakhstan and Uzbekistan have been seeking expansion of contacts beyond Russia and China.

13 Patranobis, Sutirtho (2014), "Striking Strategic Alliance with India My Historical Mission: Xi Jinping," *The Hindustan Times*, 20 March. Accessed 6 April 2020. www.hindustantimes.com/world/striking-strategic-alliance-with-india-my-historical-mission-xi-jinping/story-acdQBBtEs9xY3uR2RMAtEO.html.

14 Wang, Dong (2015), "Is China Trying to Push the US out of East Asia," *China Quarterly of International Strategic Studies*, Vol. 1, No. 1, pp. 59–84.

15 This view was emphasised, for instance, in the Moscow Conference on International Security organised by the Russian Defence Ministry, 23–24 May 2014. The author attended the conference.

16 Stobdan, P. (2015), "India's Stakes and Dilemma in SCO," *IDSA Comment*, 8 June. Accessed 10 June 2015. https://idsa.in/idsacomments/IndiasStakesandDilemmainSCO_pstobdan_080615.

17 Stobdan, P. (2016), "India's Stakes in SCO," *IDSA Comment*, 15 June. Accessed 20 June 2016. https://idsa.in/idsacomments/india-stakes-in-sco_pstobdan_150616.

18 Stobdan, P. (2015), "Talking Heads: Modi in Ufa," *IDSA Comment*, 8 July. Accessed 8 July 2015. https://idsa.in/idsacomments/TalkingHeadsModiinUfa_pstobdan_070715.

19 After signing the Memorandum of Obligations, the case of India's membership is sent to the respective parliaments of each member state for ratification.

20 Stobdan, P. (2016), "As Modi Heads for Tashkent, India Has More Hoops to Jump for SCO Membership," *The Wire*, 23 June. Accessed 6 April 2020. https://thewire.in/external-affairs/india-has-more-hoops-to-jump-for-sco-membership.

21 Chaudhury, Nilova Ray (2016), "India in SCO to Boost Connectivity, Ties with Russia," *Russia Beyond*, 25 June. Accessed 28 June 2016. http://in.rbth.com/economics/cooperation/2016/06/25/india-in-sco-to-boost-connectivity-ties-with-russia_606177.

22 See, Office of the Press Secretary, The White House (2016), "Joint Statement: The United States and India: Enduring Global Partners in the 21st Century," 7 June. Accessed 6 April 2020. https://obamawhitehouse.archives.gov/the-press-office/2016/06/07/joint-statement-united-states-and-india-enduring-global-partners-21st.

23 Chengappa, Raj (2016), "NSG: The Great Wall of Xi," *India Today*, 30 June. Accessed 3 July 2016. www.indiatoday.in/magazine/the-big-story/story/20160711-nsg-membership-india-china-829187-2016-06-30.